Biothaumaturgy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/62497651.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Castaspella & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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by Utter_Immolation

Summary

She was doing the right thing. She was sure of it. This would help the Rebellion.

So why did the thought of telling—confessing to—Bow and Catra and Adora, her mother and aunt…why did the idea of revealing everything make her sick?

Or

Glimmer drafts a reclusive Sorcerer named Dreer to study Adora's DNA.

“Glimmer!”

Glimmer tried to hide her instinctive grimace as her aunt's familiar cheerful tones echoed across the courtyard. She'd hoped to get to the lab before her Castaspella could see her, but the woman either had a sixth sense or a spell or both because she always seemed ready to greet her niece, regardless if Glimmer had called ahead.

“Hi, auntie,” she greeted, accepting the obligatory hug with as much grace as she could muster. Fighting it just meant more wasted time and Castaspella's pouting. “Just here to check on Dreer and his research.”

Castaspella immediately soured. “Right. Of course.”

Glimmer winced. “Auntie…”

“No, no. I…understand. Dreer's work with biothaumaturgy is… unusual, but I can't deny his intelligence. Nor can I begrudge his working with the samples, especially if Adora herself vetted and approved him.”

Glimmer gave an encouraging nod and tried to keep her eyes wide and innocent. Adora had, of course, never met Dreer. The contract written up by Dreer had never been read by the Captain; Glimmer had painstakingly traced, inked and pressed a copy of

her signature from another piece of paperwork over. The Wolverine had no clue about the entire project.

(It was…it would be fine. Adora would understand. Things would be a little…raw for a while but Adora would understand. The lives they would save…Adora would understand.)

"It might not even work, Auntie Spella," she pointed out, subtly guiding her aunt towards the school proper. The sooner they got towards a crowd of her subordinates the less likely Castaspella would try to drag her off to the village or try to talk her ear off about something or other. "The Horde has Entrapta's work and we're working from scratch, using magic. Even with Mystacor's finest she's in a whole other league."

"How are you holding up about that, Glim? I know she was your friend."

" *Was* ." Glimmer's voice is harsh, bitter. "She betrayed us. She's helping the Horde." Deep down, Glimmer knows it's not quite that cut and dry but what does that matter when Entrapta's off making death bots and Adorapaste to make it easier for the Horde to destroy everything they love? How can it matter when she's the one attending funerals because one of Entrapta's new toys blew a house and everyone inside to smithereens? It didn't. "She's no friend of mine. She made her choice."

"We all make choices," Castaspella murmurs, tone unusually subdued and gaze distant. "No one ever really tells you how difficult it is to live with them though."

Glimmer wonders what choices haunt her aunt. Do they concern her father? Her mother? Mystacor? It occurs to her that she's never really asked. Never really tried to. That she doesn't really know her aunt at all.

Castaspella shakes off her mood and smiles brightly at her niece in a stunning whiplash of emotion. “Ah well! I won't take up too much of your time. I know my little hero is busy saving the world! You want me to escort you to Dreer's lab?”

“Nah, I'll be fine. Thanks anyway Aunt Spella.”

“Of course! Find me before you leave, we'll get lunch!”

“Ah…I'm kind of on a schedule…”

“Of course, of course! Rebellion never sleeps! Tell your friends I say hello! I'm almost done with your magicat friend's ear warmers —ah, but that's a secret! I should mail some fudge this week, I'm making a batch. Oh, but you're busy! Run along, Glim-glim, tell them Auntie Casta says hi!”

“And mom?”

“Mm.” Castaspella walked off with unusual swiftness.

Glimmer smirked. The rivalry between her mother and aunt was never not entertaining. For two women who prided themselves on poise, they certainly knew how and when to get under each other's skin.

The smile fades as she gets closer to the medical wing of Mystacor's massive campus. She could teleport directly there but she finds herself dragging her feet. Mystacor's non-aggressive bustle was refreshingly peaceful—a stark contrast to the constant tension underlying Brightmoon, where a servant or guard hurrying could be the sign heralding another burning town, or another dead Rebellion cell or Adora coming back covered in blood again.

Ugh, Adora. She and Catra seemed to fight constantly these days. If She-Ra wasn't scouring the edges of Rebel territory and searching for news about Grizzlor, she was "training" or saying cryptic things about "destiny". Catra in turn was snapping at her one moment or avoiding her the next. She'd even moved out of their room, setting up a cot in her office and ignoring Adora's wounded and oddly ravenous gaze.

Privately, Glimmer agreed with Mermista's assertion that they needed to make-out (well, Glimmer said 'make-out', Mermista's terminology was far more explicit) already.

As it was, their distraction with each other meant that Glimmer's movements weren't as noticeable. Probably. Maybe. Bow was starting to look at her funny—concern, confusion…suspicion.

The guilt surges as she reaches Dreer's lab. She was doing the right thing. She was sure of it. This would help the Rebellion. And once they had a working, sustainable model, it could maybe even help the world. Magic was wondrous, but it couldn't do everything. It took time, effort, material…gold. But a solution that could repair entire limbs and regrow organs in moments? That could eradicate even the most stubborn diseases, counteract poisons, save countless lives? Of course it was worth it. It could change the tide of the war. The tide of Etheria.

So why did the thought of telling—confessing to—Bow and Catra and Adora, her mother and aunt…why did the idea of revealing everything make her sick?

(The war won't wait, not even for her.)

She steels herself and knocks.

"Who's there?" A voice snapped.

"It's me, Mr. Dreer."

There came the sound of hurried footsteps, the clatter of locks turning and the barely imperceptible pulse of magic being cast before the door was yanked open.

"Princess! A thousand apologies, come in, come in!"

Dreer was only a few years older than her, despite his long face, sallow periwinkle skin and somewhat greasy hair. His fingers were long and twitchy, only ever seemingly under his conscious control while in the midst of a project or experiment. His eyes were the same way, dark orbs constantly blinking until he was focused on something, like right now, gaze unsettlingly steady as they peered at her eagerly.

"Princess Glimmer! Let me thank you again for this wonderful opportunity! The things I've learned just in the last two months alone—! The samples you provided were minimal but they alone could fuel my research for decades, and the papers I'll—"

Glimmer knew from experience that the man could get going and never stop. "Dreer, we don't have decades."

A flicker of annoyance flashed over his face. "Yes, yes, I know, but we have to set the basics up before we start building a feasible product." He gestured to the lab proper, a small, cluttered room with several tables full of tubes, racks, lenses and crystals. A small wooden chair was shoved in a corner with a pillow and a rumpled, threadbare blanket draped over it.

One table was clearer than the rest and had well over a dozen petri dishes carefully laid out upon it. Glimmer wandered over and peered at them, recoiling at one in particular which was pinkish and thin and had half a dozen pale, stubby blonde hairs sticking out of what was clearly a thriving skin sample. "We're running out of time."

“I know.” He pauses, his eyes taking on that unsettling gleam once again. “Perhaps…with more samples…?”

Glimmer hesitates, her hand drifting to her pocket.

Dreer took an aborted step forward, hands twitching. “You have another?”

“You're only to reproduce a viable version of Adorapaste.”

He frowns. “That's so…limiting. She-Ra is astounding on a biological and thaumaturgical level. We're—we're not just looking at a solution, we're looking at *evolution* ! We can do more than *fix* soldiers, we can *enhance* them. Make them *more* . Make our own. We can—”

Glimmer drew herself up, doing her level best to channel her mother. “ *No!* We will not be…be *crafting* people to throw them into a meat grinder! That's what the Horde does and we are *better* . We're the good guys! Adorapaste and *that's it* .”

“But—”

“That's a royal decree, Mr. Dreer.”

He opened his mouth again, seemingly to protest, before he clamped it shut, lips thinning. His fingers twitched. For a split second, Glimmer thought she saw something ugly in his eyes.

And then he slumped. “I understand.”

Glimmer eyed him a moment longer, a faint unease rolling in the back of her mind but the man looked properly contrite. She reached into her pocket and withdrew a sealed baggie, the contents of which made Dreer gasp.

It was a piece of broken claw, about the length of her palm and razor sharp if held wrong—she'd had to use her own pilfered supply of Horde brand Adorapaste after she'd picked it up following an ambush in the Woods and it had proceeded to slice her index finger down nearly to the bone. Carefully, she passed it over to Dreer, who conjured a pair of chainmail gloves and took it from her with an uncomfortable reverence. “Will this help?”

“Yes,” he responded hoarsely. “Yes, I think it will.”

He seemed to completely forget she was there, already taking the claw to one of his tables and muttering to himself.

“You'll report in at least a month, right?”

“—carbon structures—hmm? Oh yes, of course, your Highness.” He had half a mind to scrape a bow but it was clear his attention was occupied by his latest prize and Glimmer let herself out.

The corridors were empty save rows and rows of those ancient statues, looming marble figures of long dead sorcerers, sorceresses and scholars, stone gazes staring blankly into the ether. And yet as she walked off, seized by the urge to find her aunt and bid her farewell, Glimmer couldn't help but feel that they were watching her…and judging.

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